



Pure emotion: Against the odds and from the bottom of the seedings, R. Vaishali rose to the top of the Women's Candidates, sealing the title by half a point. Here, she shares a quiet, heartfelt celebration with her mother, Nagalakshmi, and Grandmaster M. Pranesh, after receiving the trophy.

"I think in the first half, my games were super shaky. I was just scoring points by luck. The loss against Zhu was very crucial. In the second half, my game started to become better," explained Vaishali in the post-tournament press conference.

Zhu would return later to halt Vaishali's momentum with a dominant win in Round 12, setting up a thrilling finish. Heading into the final round, Vaishali was in joint lead with Kazakhstan's Bibisara Assaubayeva.

But Vaishali benefited from her compatriot Divya, who held Assaubayeva to a draw. The equation was simple: the Candidates was Vaishali's if she beat Kateryna Lagno.

With all eyes on her, Vaishali held her nerve to systematically dismantle Lagno's defence and claim the requisite point. The spotlight had never shone brighter.

When asked what changed for her in Cyprus, Vaishali replied: "I think it's just [the result of] continuous hard work. Somehow, I was not getting results in the last couple of years. I think everything came together here in this tournament."

The chaotic unfolding of the women's section stood in contrast to the procession-like nature of the open section. Javokhir Sindarov dominated the Candidates, tallying 10 points, the most any player has accumulated in a single edition.

The Uzbek GM, playing his maiden Candidates, blazed through the opening rounds, winning five of his first six games to open up a sizeable lead.

What stood out most in those early games was Sindarov's razor-sharp opening preparation, which helped him outfox his experienced opponents. This often

gave him a significant advantage on the clock, allowing him to dictate the middlegame and steer games towards inevitable wins.

In Round 5, Sindarov drew World No. 2 Hikaru Nakamura into a compromised position with precise opening play. The American struggled to untangle himself and ended up spending over 67 minutes on a move, the second-longest any player has taken for a single move in Candidates history.

Despite burning time on the clock, Hikaru chose a move (13. h4) that only worsened his position. Sindarov seized the advantage and coasted to a comfortable win.

Such was Sindarov's dominance that even a mid-tournament accidental leak of his opening routines on the online chess portal Lichess barely slowed his charge.

With the title almost secured, the 20-year-old shifted into a pragmatic